The Thief's Story

The big idea

The Thief's Story by **Ruskin Bond** is told by a young thief, **Hari Singh**, who tries to rob a kind young man, **Anil**, but returns the money because of Anil's **trust** and the hope of an **education**. It is a story of a change of heart.

Summary

- **Meeting:** Hari Singh, a **15-year-old** thief ("an experienced and fairly successful hand"), meets **Anil**, about **25**, watching a wrestling match. Hari flatters him and asks for work. Anil cannot pay him, but agrees to feed him if he cooks.
- **Learning:** Hari's first meal is so bad that Anil gives it to a stray dog, but Anil patiently teaches him to cook. Anil also begins teaching Hari to **write his name** and promises to teach him to write whole sentences and add figures. Hari is grateful.
- **Hari's cheating:** Hari makes a small profit of about a rupee a day on the shopping. Anil knows but does not mind.
- **The theft:** Anil earns money by writing for magazines. One day he brings home a **bundle of notes (₹600)** and puts it under his mattress. That night Hari, deciding it is time to move on, steals the money and plans to catch the **10:30 express to Lucknow**.
- **Change of heart:** At the station, Hari hesitates. He thinks of Anil's face when he discovers the theft — not anger, but **sadness**. He realises that if he leaves, he loses the chance of learning to read and write, which could make him "a big man". He does not board the train.
- **Returning the money:** It is raining; he returns, wet, and slips the **damp notes** back under the mattress.

- **The ending:** The next morning Anil gives him a **₹50 note**, saying he made some money and Hari will now be paid regularly. Hari notices the note is still **wet** — so Anil knows, but says nothing. Anil says they will start writing sentences that day.

WHY HARI RETURNED THE MONEY

1. Anil's **trust and kindness** — he was easy to rob because he trusted completely.
2. The value of **education** — reading and writing could make him respectable and successful.

Characters

Character	Traits
Hari Singh	clever, observant, a skilled thief, but sensitive and capable of change; values education
Anil	kind, trusting, generous, tolerant; a struggling writer; forgives silently

ANIL DID NOT CATCH HARI

Anil never says he knew. The **wet note** silently shows that he knew and forgave him.

Themes and value points

- **Trust and kindness** can reform a person more than punishment.
- **Education** is the key to a better life.
- Everyone deserves a second chance.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What did Hari think about different kinds of people he robbed? Why did he not board the train? How did Hari know Anil had discovered the theft? Character sketch of Anil.

Quick recap

- Ruskin Bond; narrator Hari Singh (15), Anil (25), writer.
- Anil teaches cooking and writing; ₹600 stolen and returned.
- Wet ₹50 note → Anil knew and forgave.
- Themes: trust, change of heart, education.

Practice questions

1. How old was Hari Singh?
   (a) 12 (b) 15 (c) 20 (d) 25
2. Where did Hari first meet Anil?
   (a) At a railway station (b) At a market (c) At a wrestling match (d) At a school
3. Where did Anil keep the money?
   (a) In a bank (b) Under his mattress (c) In a drawer (d) In his pocket
4. Which train did Hari plan to catch?
   (a) The Delhi mail (b) The Bombay express (c) The Lucknow express (d) The Calcutta mail
5. Why did Hari return the money?
   (a) He was caught by the police (b) He was afraid of Anil (c) He missed the train by mistake (d) He valued Anil's trust and the chance to learn to read and write
6. How did Hari know that Anil had discovered the theft?
   (a) The fifty-rupee note was still wet (b) Anil scolded him (c) Anil called the police (d) Anil counted the money in front of him
7. How did Anil's trust and kindness bring about a change in Hari Singh?

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. b 4. c 5. d 6. a 7. see notes